

Jiaxin An

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Research focus

My research aims to (1) advance the understanding of human behavior through the lens of information science and (2) apply this knowledge to address societal challenges arising from rapid technological development. Currently, my research focuses on developing agentic systems that empower vulnerable populations in information-seeking contexts. Specifically:

- I examine *autonomy*, a fundamental characteristic of agentic systems and a core ethical principle in human life. As technological advancements enable agentic systems to function autonomously, I seek to understand how these systems can be designed to enhance rather than diminish human autonomy.
- I focus on *aging populations*, a rapidly growing demographic whose autonomy is often compromised by physical and cognitive decline, as well as by social stigmatization stemming from ageism.

Education

Ph.D. in Information Studies / The University of Texas at Austin

AUG 2021 - PRESENT, AUSTIN, TX

Advisor: Dr. Yan Zhang

M.S., Library Science / Peking University

JUL 2018 - JUN 2020, BEIJING, CHINA

Advisor: Dr. Pengyi Zhang

Thesis: The health information behavior of parents of children with ASD (Autism Spectrum Disorder)

B.S., Library Science & B.S., Psychology / Peking University

JUL 2014 - JUN 2018, BEIJING, CHINA

Publication

Archived papers

An, J., Yi, S., Lyu, Y., Liu, H., & Zhang, Y. (2025). Conversational Agents for Older Adults' Health: A Systematic Literature Review. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2503.23153*.

Zhang, Y., An, J., Wang, B., Zhang, Y., & Liu, J. (2025). Human-Centered Explainability in Interactive Information Systems: A Survey. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2507.02300*.

Journal Papers

An, J., Fan, W., Mittal, A., Zhang, Y., & Chen, A. (2024). Mobile App Use among Persons with Fibromyalgia: A Cross-Sectional Survey. *The Journal of Pain*. DOI: 10.1016/j.jpain.2024.03.011

Choi, W., Bak, H., An, J., Zhang, Y., & Stvilia, B. (2024). College students' credibility assessments of GenAI-generated information for academic tasks: An interview study. *Journal of the Association for Information Science and Technology*.

Conference Papers

An, J., Na, Y., & Zhang, P. (2019). How do parents of children with ASD use information grounds to seek for ASD-related information? *Proceedings of the Association for Information Science and Technology*, 56(1), 10-20.

An, J., Li, T., Teng, Y., & Zhang, P. (2018, March). Factors influencing emoji usage in smartphone mediated communications. In *International Conference on Information* (pp. 423-428). Springer, Cham.

Zhe, W., An, J., & Zhang, P. (2017). Activity patterns of collaborative sensemaking in small discussion groups. *iConference 2017 Proceedings* (pp. 498-506).

Peer-Reviewed Posters

An, J., Bak., H., Choi, W., Zhang, Y., & Stvilia, B. (2024). College Students' Metaphors for ChatGPT: An Exploratory Study. *Proceedings of the Association for Information Science and Technology*.

Liu, J., **An, J.**, & Zhang, P. (2020). Analyzing opinion conflicts in an online group discussion: From the perspective of majority and minority influence. *iConference 2020 Proceedings*.

An, J., Fu, Y., Wang, M., & Liu, C. (2017). To learn or not to learn? The primary school students' internet use for learning. *iConference 2017 Proceedings*.

Workshop position papers

An, J. (2025). Autonomy for Older Adult-Agent Interaction. *ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems 2025*.

 **An, J.**, Bak, H., Choi, W., Zhang, Y., & Stvilia, B. (2024). College Students' Barriers and Challenges of Using ChatGPT: An Exploratory Study. *Annual Meeting of the Association for Information Science and Technology*. (Student Travel Award)

An, J. (2023). Resilience in parents' caregiving for children with ASD (Autism Spectrum Disorder): an exploratory study. *ACM Conference on Designing Interactive Systems*

Research experience

The University of Texas at Austin / Research Assistant

AUG 2021 - PRESENT, AUSTIN, TX

Project 1: Human-Centered Explainability in Interactive Information System

- PI: Dr. Jiqun Liu (University of Oklahoma) and Dr. Yan Zhang
- Researching the existing design of explainability by literature review

Project 2: The Application of Generative AI in Education

- PI: Dr. Wonchan Choi (University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee), Dr. Yan Zhang, and Dr. Besiki Stvilia (Florida State University)
- Investigating students' understanding and use of Generative AI in their study through interviews and qualitative coding

Project 3: Consumer Longitudinal Health Information Needs and Search Behavior

- PI: Dr. Yan Zhang and Dr. Jacek Gwizdka
- Conducting three-month data collection (interview, diaries, and log) for each participant and analyzing data with mixed methods.

Project 4: Fibromyalgia-Related Mobile App Use

- PI: Dr. Annie T. Chen (University of Washington)
- Researching mobile app usage of people with fibromyalgia with surveys and conducting statistical tests.

The University of Texas at Austin / Research Director

JUN 2022 - present, AUSTIN, TX

Project: Conversational Agents (CAs) for Older Adults' Health

- Advisor: Dr. Yan Zhang
- Leading the group to review the existing research of CAs for assisting older adults' health;

Peking University / Research Director

JUL 2015 - JAN 2020, BEIJING, CHINA

Project 1: Information Behavior of Parents of Children with ASD

- Advisor: Dr. Pengyi Zhang
- Researching the information behavior of parents of children with ASD in caregiving through observation, interview, and qualitative analysis.

Project 2: Factors Influencing Emoji Usage in Smartphone-Mediated Communications

- Advisor: Dr. Pengyi Zhang
- Exploring emoji usage by collecting WeChat messages, qualitative coding, and statistical tests

Project 3: The Primary School Students' Internet Usage for Learning

- Advisor: Dr. Chang Liu
- Investigating students' Internet use during their study by diaries, focus groups, and qualitative coding

Teaching experience

The University of Texas at Austin / Assistant Instructor

JAN 2023 - PRESENT, AUSTIN, TX

Courses: Introduction to Informatics | Consumer Health Informatics | Information Architecture and Design | Academic Success in Digital University

Hold classes, discussion groups, and workshops for undergraduates (N=27) and master students (N=20); grading.

Peking University / Self-conducted project

SEP 2018 - MAY 2020, BEIJING, CHINA

Courses: Information Organization

Hold discussion classes for undergraduates (N=12); Design syllabus, assignments, examinations, and Q&A videos for online courses; teaching assistance.

Industry experience

Xiaomi Technology / User Research Intern

APR 2021 - JUL 2021, BEIJING, CHINA

- Explored the influence of voice assistants on mobile phone purchases by conducting a literature review, interviews, surveys, and online behavior data analyses.
- One of the early members to build the "Weibo public opinion monitoring" system for XiaoAI Assistant, including qualitative coding of posts in Weibo and cooperation with developers to automate coding with Machine Learning.
- The findings provide insights into the commercial strategies and optimization points of XiaoAI. The "Weibo public opinion monitoring" system was selected as one of the "Quality Star" programs in 2023.

Ferrum Health / User Research Intern

JUL 2018 - AUG 2018, SAN FRANCISCO, CA

- Conducted an interview study on Chinese physicians' attitudes toward AI CT scanners.
- The findings help the team understand the concerns of Chinese physicians on AI in medicine.
- This internship is funded by the CHINA-US Program for Entrepreneurship and Innovation (CUSPEI)

Didi Chuxing / Product Manager Assistant

JUL 2017 - JAN 2018, BEIJING, CHINA

- Conducted data analysis with SPSS and SQL to support the algorithm design of order distribution
- Conducted an interview study on the user experience of ride-sharing drivers and riders

Skills

- **Software:** NVivo, MAXQDA, SPSS, Excel, Axure, Sketch, Figma
- **Research methods:** Experienced in qualitative methods, e.g., surveys, observation, interviews, focus groups, and diaries. Familiar with quantitative methods, e.g., experiment design and statistical test.
- **Coding:** Basic knowledge of Python, SQL, HTML, CSS

- **Language:** Chinese, English.

Services

Reviewer: CHI 23/24/25; CUI 24; CSCW 24/25; ASIS&T 19/21/24/25; iConference 18/24; CHIIR 23/24; Humanities and Social Sciences Communications (HSSCOMMS); Information Research

Volunteer: DIS 23; iConference 18; CHIIR 23

Awards

Student Travel Award by the SIG-AI LLM Workshop in ASIS&T (2024)

University of Texas at Austin Graduate School Summer Excellence Fellowship (2023 - 2025)

University of Texas at Austin College Recruitment Fellowship (2021 - 2022)

Excellent Award in the Graduate Student Symposium in ALIRG 2019

Dayuan Wu & Suiqiao Chen Scholarship, Peking University (Top 1 in library science) (2017)

Merit Student, Peking University (Top 10%) (2017)

“Challenge Cup” Academic Competition 2nd Prize, Peking University (2016)